



Cowboy country: A Messi No. 10 jersey stands out against the cowboy backdrop as World Cup fever takes over Dallas. REUTERS

FROM DALLAS NIGHTS TO A MAD DASH THROUGH MANHATTAN

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For a week, the town belonged to Argentinians as the team played back-to-back games against Austria

and Jordan. At every bar and every 7-Eleven, you would bump into South Americans. The city, after England fans had run it dry following their team's group-stage victory over Croatia, had learned from its mistake. Every pub had hundreds of kegs lined up outside, taking over the footpaths much like the street hawkers of Kolkata or Mumbai.

The stay at the Magnolia Hotel, built in 1922 as the Magnolia Petroleum Building, was convenient. This 29-storey Beaux-Arts skyscraper was the tallest building in Texas for decades and is famously capped by the iconic 40-foot neon Pegasus. More importantly, it was a minute's walk from the AT&T Discovery

District's central plaza and media wall, which became the site of impromptu watch parties for games involving Mexico, Argentina and the United States. Garden chairs and picnic mats took over the square as families made an evening of the games, with margaritas and food flowing as freely as the goals in this World Cup.

But the proximity ensured there would be no early nights, and no sleep at all until 2 a.m., when the square was finally cleared.

The energy and excitement didn't allow the circadian cycle to adjust to the changing time zones, from India to the East Coast and then Central Time. That's why making the